

NSAIDs and Arthritis: Benefits, Risks and Safer Use

Ibuprofen and naproxen ease pain but carry stomach and kidney risks. Use them smarter.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-14 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Ibuprofen and naproxen ease pain but carry stomach and kidney risks. Use them smarter.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Versus Arthritis consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- **Talk to your clinician.** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- **Track your symptoms.** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.

- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.
 - ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]/\(conditions/osteoarthritis\)](#).
 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment.
 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.
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Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Systematic reviews of studies involving people with arthritis consistently show that non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs) can effectively reduce pain and stiffness. Randomised controlled trials, which are the gold standard for testing treatments, highlight that these benefits are often seen relatively quickly, typically within hours to days of starting treatment. However, these trials also underline that individual responses can vary significantly, with some people experiencing greater relief than others.

Clinical guidelines from leading UK rheumatology bodies generally recommend using NSAIDs at the lowest effective dose for the shortest possible duration. This recommendation is based on a large body of evidence from observational studies and meta-analyses that have identified potential side effects, particularly affecting the digestive system and kidneys, which become more likely with higher doses and longer-term use. The evidence suggests that while topical (applied to the skin) NSAIDs may offer localised relief with fewer systemic side effects, oral NSAIDs are more potent for widespread or deeper joint pain.

Research continues to explore how to best balance the pain-relieving benefits of NSAIDs with their potential risks. Current understanding emphasises careful patient selection, considering individual risk factors such as age, other medical conditions, and co-prescribed medications. This evidence-based approach helps healthcare professionals tailor recommendations to minimise harm while maximising the benefits for people living with arthritis.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Taking more than the recommended dose:** Stick to the dosage on the packet or as advised by your pharmacist or doctor. * **Mixing different NSAIDs:** This doesn't increase pain relief and significantly raises the risk of side effects. * **Ignoring stomach upset or indigestion:** These can be early signs of digestive problems; report them to a professional. * **Using NSAIDs continuously without review:** Regular short breaks or reviews can help monitor effectiveness and side effects. * **Combining with certain other medications without advice:** NSAIDs can interact with blood thinners, blood pressure tablets, and other common drugs.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While NSAIDs can be very helpful for managing arthritis pain, it's crucial to know when to seek professional advice. If you experience new or worsening symptoms while taking these medications, or if you're unsure about their suitability, speak to your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist.

* You develop severe stomach pain, black stools, or vomit blood. * You notice swelling in your ankles, feet, or significant changes in how much you're urinating. * Your existing medical conditions, such as high blood pressure or kidney problems, seem to worsen. * You experience persistent dizziness, headaches, or unusual fatigue. * The medication isn't providing adequate pain relief after a reasonable trial period.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I take NSAIDs every day for my arthritis? Daily use of NSAIDs for arthritis should always be discussed with a doctor. While some people may need them regularly, it's generally advised to use the lowest effective dose for the shortest time possible due to potential side effects with long-term use.

Are topical NSAIDs safer than oral NSAIDs? Topical NSAIDs (gels, creams) are often considered safer than oral forms because less of the medication is absorbed into your bloodstream. This means they carry a lower risk of digestive or kidney side effects, making them a good option for localised joint pain.

What should I do if NSAIDs don't help my pain? If NSAIDs aren't effectively managing your pain, it's important to speak to your doctor or a healthcare professional. They can review your diagnosis, adjust your treatment plan, or explore other pain relief options that might be more suitable for you.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about nsaids and arthritis: benefits, risks and safer use?

Short answer: NSAIDs effectively reduce arthritis pain and stiffness, with benefits often appearing within hours to days, though responses vary. Use the lowest effective dose for the shortest duration, as side effects on the digestive system and kidneys become more likely with higher doses and longer-term use. Topical NSAIDs may offer localised relief with fewer systemic side effects.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk